

PORTABLE MEDIA PLAYERS

Ascertain whether you want a device for music listening, Web surfing or gaming. Also what price range are you looking at? The most important consideration, however, is the memory required for your listening habits

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Portable media players are in vogue among the youth. Coming in different colours and shapes, these are basically digital audio players that can also play images and videos. Though cellphones and laptops too are capable of these functions, the term 'portable media player' is usually used for those devices which are wearable and solely dedicated to playing multimedia.

You might be one amongst many contemplating to buy a portable media player. Here is how to choose the best from the variety available.

What's available?

Portable media players are offered by companies like Sony, Apple, Creative, Microsoft, Philips, Samsung and Zebtronics. Amongst these, Microsoft's Zune player is currently unavailable in India.

There are various different models available in the market. The range starts with the basic models that play MP3/WMA files and have no screen. The next models usually have small screens, to display the song ID tags.



Then come the players with a colour screen that is usually 5cm (2-inch) or bigger in size. These may or may not come with touch-screen as smaller touch-screens are not very comfortable to use. Usually, touch-screen models have a larger screen and easier interface to use.

Portable media players may also feature wireless connectivity to the Internet. So you can browse and download music and video files to the device. For instance, Apple's iPod touch (4th Generation) allows you to wirelessly access the iTunes Store and also Apple's App Store, enabling content to be purchased and downloaded directly on the device. It features touch-screen, camera and gaming too.

Sony offers a wide range of Walkman MP3 players. The recently introduced Walkman E series (E353 and E354) combines fun, form and function and delivers a rich audio performance with clarity and precision.

Selection criteria

Choose a portable media player depending on your usage, budget and even preference for type of music. Ascertain whether you want a portable device for music listening, Web surfing or gaming. Also, what price range are you looking at? The most important consideration, however, is the memory required for your listening habits.

Type of storage

You may want to carry along entire libraries of your songs, pictures and videos. Some players may even let you load small games. Ideally, a portable media player should have adequate internal memory with the option of expanding it.

There are two types of widely used storage formats: flash and hard disk. Capacities of flash type range from less than 1 GB to 32 GB. Hard disk models are available from around 16 GB to even 120 GB.

Flash-based players are generally